



Andover Village
Improvement Society
Founded 1894

Fall 2026
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Open to All: Celebrating AVIS's First All Persons Trail

By Susan Stott, AVIS Trustee

On May 16, 2026, AVIS Trustees gathered with supporters and friends to celebrate AVIS's first All Persons Trail at the Goldsmith Woodlands. Below we share the remarks made that day by Project Leader Susan Stott.

Thank you everyone who is here today to celebrate the completion of AVIS's first All Persons Trail. During COVID we saw people flock to the AVIS reservations and learned this trail is the right thing to do so people with mobility challenges could enjoy being in the woods.

First, I want to thank David Dargie, who has been an extraordinary partner in this project. We would not be standing here today without David's knowledge, commitment and hours of work.

Donors

Thank you to the AVIS Trustees and donors, and to everyone who has supported the construction of the All Persons Trail. Thank you to the Massachusetts Department of Conservation and Recreation. Its MassTrails Grant gave AVIS hope we could raise the funds.

Thank you to The Boston Foundation (TBF)

The Goldsmith Woodlands were left in trust by Bessie Goldsmith in 1966. AVIS entered into an agreement to maintain the reservation about 50 years ago. TBF helped fund the acquisition of the parking area in 2000. After AVIS asked TBF to help fund the trail it not only gave a major grant but also transferred the 140-acre Goldsmith Woodlands to AVIS.

Three foundations supported the gift of land

They helped AVIS acquire 26 acres along the Merrimack River 10 years ago and responded generously when asked to support this trail for people of all abilities: The Highland Street Foundation and David McGrath, The Bafflin Foundation in Providence, R.I., and the Fields Pond Foundation.

Other important gifts

Thank you to the Rotary Club of Andover, the Andover Chamber of Commerce and the Rockland Trust for their grants to support this project, and to the Edgewood Life/Care Community that donated the Rough Rider Wheelchair we are using today.

Thank you to Justin Coppola, the former chair, and Steve Surrette, the current chair of the Andover Committee on Disability, and members from the Massachusetts Office on Disability who came out and advised AVIS about its All Persons Trail before we knew we could reduce the grades to take the trail all the way out to Bessie's Point.

AVIS was turned down on its first MassTrails Grant application. Janet Nicosia helped us frame a successful proposal a year later. A shout out to Janet and to the Town for opening the Haggetts Pond Trail earlier this month.

continued >



Above: Cathy French, a longtime AVIS member, cuts the ribbon to open the All Persons Trail on May 16, 2026, surrounded by AVIS trustees. Photograph by Bob Gilbert

Left: Guests awaiting the opening of the All Persons Trail. Photograph by Mike Timko.

Construction

Thank you to GPI and especially to Ron Headrick who has shared his time pro bono long before AVIS hired GPI to help us to develop our successful MassTrails Grant application. With grant in hand, GPI developed a plan for both the trail and the parking improvements to submit to the Conservation Commission. Thank you to Sam Campbell who helped us navigate an approval with the Conservation Commission and lastly, thank you to Bob White who made sure the trail was built to Forest Service Trail Accessibility Guidelines (FSTAG).

The AMC Professional Team

Thank you to the Appalachian Mountain Club Professional Trail Team who camped out in Harold Parker Forest from Monday to Thursday every week from July to October 2025. The crew constructed a trail that is six feet wide filled with six inches of crushed stone, and leads all the way to Bessie's Point. Despite the late start they finished all but the last 300 feet of the trail and returned to complete it at the end of April this year.

And finally, thank you to Marty Dudek and to David Gutbrod of Commonwealth Cultural & Archaeological Assessors LLC, who prepared an archaeological sensitivity survey in record time, as well as to the Andover Consultants Inc., to Retelle Tree Corporation and to J White Contracting for the work they did on this project.

The future: AVIS was recently awarded an Essex Heritage grant for signage to Bessie's Point. Suzanne Korschun, who designed the AVIS kiosks during Covid, will work with an AVIS committee to design this signage.

AVIS has raised about \$530,000 for the Goldsmith project to date. AVIS has about \$100,000 in hand toward an estimated \$500,000 needed to provide an Americans with Disabilities Act – compliant parking for 22 vehicles. These improvements will replicate the wetlands needed for the parking lot expansion and will improve traffic safety. AVIS will reach out to all of its generous donors with the goal to have funds in hand to construct the parking improvements in 2027.

Thank you for supporting this important project to make the Goldsmith Woodlands and Bessie's Point accessible to people of all abilities especially when the lady slippers are in bloom, as they are today.



Left: Disability advocate Justin Coppola, who served 25 years on the Andover Commission on Disability, shares that the AVIS All Persons Trail turns nature for some into nature for everyone, including his son. "It removes barriers that keep people out of nature. An APT supports physical and mental health, and emotional well-being. It allows families to be together... to be together without barriers or compromises." Photograph by Annie Gilbert.



Right: A member of the Appalachian Mountain Club trail crew, Lindsey Stanley, shares her adventures in construction. Photograph by Judy Timko

President's Letter

On May 16, AVIS Trustees gathered with supporters and members of the disability community to celebrate the opening of our first All Persons Trail at the Goldsmith Woodlands Reservation. It was a beautiful day and a thrilling mile-



stone, and we are so pleased to welcome visitors of all abilities to our new trail. Huge thanks go to AVIS Trustee Susan Stott, who led this complicated initiative, and to Land Manager David Dargie for his careful project oversight. We are grateful for the incredible support of the community, but our work is not finished: Phase Two of the project will focus on improving accessibility and visitor safety at the trail entrance and providing substantial additional parking. You can help by participating in our Phase II Matching Gift Challenge, launching this fall.

We are also pleased to report the recent expansion of the Stanley Reservation thanks to a generous bequest from the Georgia Stanley Estate. This gift of a beautiful three-acre parcel at the corner of Porter and Spring Grove roads adds to Georgia Stanley's original donation of 8.29 acres back in 1987. AVIS will plan and mow a trail on the new parcel later this summer.

We never lose sight of how fortunate we are to have the help of so many talented volunteers. In this issue I'd like to pay particular thanks to Muthu Aruguram, who for many years has done a fantastic job as AVIS's webmaster. He has our sincere gratitude as he passes the torch to Lynn Landry and Lezz Giles. I'd also like to thank Bruce Littlefield for leading the group that created the beautiful new 7th Edition of the Andover Trails Guide. Bruce and his team of AVIS and Andover Trails Committee leaders have put together an outstanding book that will be available for purchase this fall.

See you on the trails!

Annie Gilbert

An interview with Warden Kevin Keller and his partner, Nigel

By Alix Driscoll

“It’s a blessing for me,” shares AVIS Warden Kevin Keller, as he speaks in hushed tones of 26-acre Ann Rawlins Greene Reservation hard by the Historic BallardVale Village. “I just love the serenity and quiet.”

From our interview perch along the ridge line of the glacial esker rising from Indian Ridge near Andover High School, Keller surveys the peaceful vista, especially so when the leaves are down. He is often accompanied by his trusty pal, Nigel, an English Springer Spaniel, his fourth. Keller is proud to share that Nigel is a working Therapy Dog, “a Canine Good Citizen.”

But sometimes Keller needs to punctuate his quiet visits to the Greene Reservation with chain saw cuts of the scary widow makers and the trees blown down in the recent superbust.

“I am the chainsaw guy, and my fellow warden, Paul Dick, does much of the trail work.”

Volunteer work for the Conservation Commission with Bob DeCelle on the Town’s Mary French Reservation also complements Keller’s AVIS service. “I just love the maintenance work with some thinning of trees for better air flow.” In the winter he dons a headlamp and snowshoes to traverse the trails.

And looking forward, Keller plans to integrate the Ann Rawlins Greene Reservation more closely into the neighboring Ballard-Vale community.

“I spend between two and three hours a week at the Greene Reservation. Obviously, the hours increase when trees and debris are down after storms.”

Nigel’s Day Jobs

Keller is proud to share that in addition to accompanying him on his trail work at the Greene Reservation, Nigel visits the residents of the five Senior Living facilities including the memory-impaired residents every other Monday. He eagerly checks up on visitors at the Supportive Day Program at The Robb Senior Center. Frequent visits to youngsters at The Temple Emanuel Preschool are

a highlight of Nigel’s days and he also loves going to visit the staff at the town offices and the Andover Department of Public Works folks, according to Keller.

Birdlife at the Anne Rawlings Green Reservation includes Bard Owls, Cooper Hawks and Red Tail Hawks plus falcons. The mythical and notably shy Ballardvale white squirrels visit and bobcats roam free.

A short while ago, Trustee John Hess realized that Warden Paul Dick might need some help with the maintenance of the Greene Reservation and asked Keller to help out; and thus, was created a new warden, Kevin Keller, with his pal, Nigel, ready to greet one and all at “their” reservation.



Kevin Keller, Warden of Ann Rawlins Greene Reservation, with his companion English Springer Spaniel, Nigel. Photograph by Ellen Keller.

New AVIS Members, June 1, 2025 to June 1, 2026

Susan Ayles	Alec MacGregor
Jeffrey Coop	McGuiness Group, Inc.
Grace Curley	Jason Messinger
Barbara Dean	Linda Metzger
Bruce Dunbar	Michael J, Meyers
Kenneth Dupuis	Monica Morell
Scott Erickson	Joy Nemergut
Gary Gearin	Jonathan Pierce
Elizabeth Hoehn	Alisha Sharina and
Kay Hussainee	Rahul Handoo
Linda Ireland	Kathleen and Richard Tiberii
Diane Jannetti	Michael Toth
Shepard Johnson	

AVIS 2025 Unaudited Financials from the 2026 Annual Meeting

Profit and Loss

Income and Gains:	\$359,000
Expenses:	\$98,000
Net Income:	\$261,000

Balance Sheet

Cash and Endowments:	\$1,481,000
Fixed Assets and Land:	\$6,054,000
TOTAL Assets:	\$7,535,000
Accruals and Equity:	\$7,535,000

By Mark Kaluzny, Treasurer

Kiran Cox is the First Girl to Do Her Eagle Scout Project for AVIS

By Buzz Stapczynski

To earn her Eagle Scout award, Kiran Cox decided to do trail improvements for AVIS on the Deer Jump Trail. She designed, procured the materials and led her crew in the construction of two much needed boardwalks and a set of steps. She started construction of one of the boardwalks and the steps in late November and early December of 2025, just as snow and bad weather were beginning. She and her crew built the second boardwalk in late winter/early spring. When asked about what she learned from this leadership project, she said she didn't expect that working in winter conditions would be so difficult and that it was a challenge leading Scouts of different ages and abilities. She learned how to keep her crew on task without "hovering" over them.

Cox graduated from Pingree School in June, where she was active in the theater program and was the coxswain in the varsity boat for four years. She will be attending Skidmore College.



Eagle Scout Kiran Cox (in front on steps), surrounded by her work team: (left to right) Tommy Schmidt, Nolan Janas, Eleanor Townsend-Hanneman, and Chris Schmidt. Photograph by Lakshmi Cox



For many decades Lindsey Brook Chandler has graciously designed the AVIS Update newsletters with an artist's eye and sophistication. On the Nat Smith Reservation where her dad, Mike Timko, is warden, during the rainy seasons there appears a brook named for her in gratitude. Meet Lindsey Brook. Photograph by Mike Timko

Suzanne Korschun wins award for Bessie's Point signage

By Alix Driscoll

Well into the planning stage, Suzanne Korschun, the graphic designer, is creating signage that dovetails well with the accessible features of the All Persons Trail at Bessie's Point at the Goldsmith Woodlands. To last many decades, it will sport metal feet. It will be tailored as a lower structure than most kiosks for easy reading by the trail's visitors. Designed with the needs of folks with disabilities in mind, the signage will engage visitors with larger fonts and contrasts for the texts. QR codes will unlock further information on the visitors technological devices. Cell phones could allow the ability to translate information into other languages. Korschun will pay attention to the height of the signs and a possibility for a Braille feature.

"This trail is so special. It is important to meet the needs of all of the people using this trail," she agreed.

And so did the Essex Heritage Commission, giving her the Interpretive Signage Award for the signage at Bessie's Point on the All Persons Trail in May.

"I like to give back to my community. Hopefully, this signage will be a gift for all in the AVIS community."



Photograph by Sabrina Osborn

Deer Jump Habitat Restoration Project

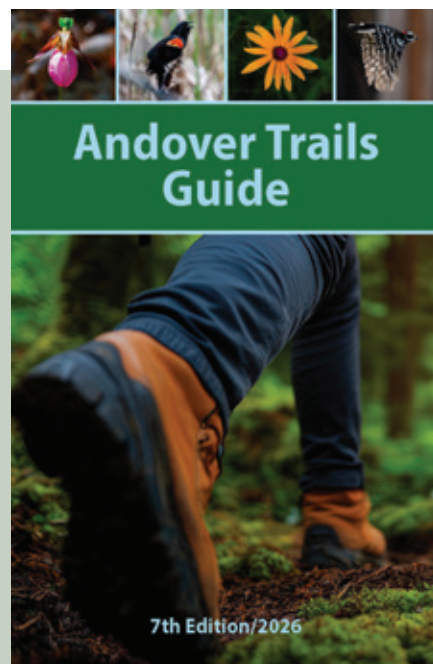
By Amy Janovsky and Kelly Jork, AVIS Trustees

American beech trees, already affected by severe drought, are succumbing to two diseases: Beech bark disease (top photo) and Beech leaf disease (middle photo). AVIS is working to establish new trees and shrubs under the canopy of dying beech trees on the Deer Jump Reservation, using native plants supplied by the MA Department of Conservation and Recreation. Please note the deer resistant cages that will help these valuable plants grow to a size that can survive some level of deer browse. We would love volunteers to help keep the young plants watered during the severe drought. If you'd like to help, please email Volunteer@AVISandover.org and put "Watering Help" in the subject line.



Top: Beech Bark Disease; Middle: Beech Leaf Disease;
Bottom left: Deer Jump Reservation habitat restoration project;
Bottom right: Deer resistant cages. Photographs by Kelly Jork

The 7th Edition of the Andover Trails Guide is for sale. The Guide is a joint publication between AVIS and the Andover Trails Committee. It has updated information, property descriptions and added reservations not covered before. There is information on recommended hikes.



A Trails and Sails event on Sept 20, 10:00 a.m. at the Goldsmith Woodlands

By Mark Kaluzny, AVIS Trustee

Come and explore the AVIS Goldsmith Woodlands with Mark Kaluzny. We'll hike a 5.0-mile loop with an elevation gain of 160 ft. Meet at the Peggy Keck Reservation parking lot at 9:45 a.m. We'll start on the new All Persons Trail (APT) and visit some favorite spots, including Journey's End, Bessie's Point and Scout Hollow.

To register, visit AVISandover.org/events, contact Treasurer@avisandover.org or call 603-531-9895 with questions.

Eco Team Fall Work Schedule

By Lynn Landry, Eco Team, Lead

Aug. 29	Saturday	8:30 – 11 a.m.
Sept. 12	Saturday	8:30 – 11 a.m.
Sept. 19	Saturday	10:00 a.m. – 4 p.m., Andover Day, downtown
Sept. 26	Saturday	8:30 – 11 a.m.
Oct. 10	Saturday	8:30 – 11 a.m.
Oct. 18	Sunday	1:00 – 3:30 p.m.
Oct. 24	Saturday	8:30 – 11 a.m.
Nov. 1	Sunday	1:00 – 3:30 p.m.
Nov. 14	Saturday	8:30 – 11 a.m.
Nov. 28	Saturday	8:30 – 11 a.m.



AVIS Membership

Name: _____

Address: _____

Town, State, Zip: _____

Phone: _____

Email: _____

Dues: _____ \$30 Individual _____ \$100 Sustaining
 _____ \$50 Family _____ \$15 Student & Senior

Join or renew online at www.avisandover.org/join or
send a check made payable to "AVIS" to:

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For information about planned giving or stock donations
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tax deductible to the extent permitted by federal regulations.
Thank you!

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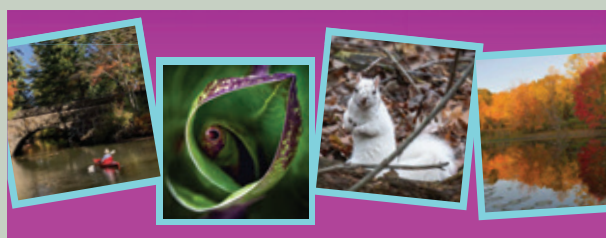
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For additional AVIS events see
AVISANDOVER.ORG

To check for other hikes visit
ANDOVERTRAILS.ORG

For AMC walks see
AMCBOSTON.ORG

The AVIS Update is a biannual publication of The Andover Village Improvement Society. The mission of AVIS is to acquire and preserve Andover land in its natural state. More than 1,200 acres of land are managed by AVIS and are open to all for passive recreation.



Our third **AVIS Land Trust photo contest**
"AVIS: Andover's Treasure" is now open to
photographers of all skill levels and ages.

- Walk one of our 30 reservations and 30 miles of trails.
- Start taking photos that capture the essence of our properties, iconic sites, and landscapes.
- Enter and win our photo contest.

Deadline for submissions is January 30, 2027
See rules, category descriptions and competition
information at AvisAndover.org/Photocontest
or scan the QR code to the right.



Prizes and Exhibition

One Grand Prize winner
will be awarded a \$75 prize;
first place category winners
will be awarded \$50 prizes,
and runner-up category
winners will be awarded
\$25 prizes. Winners and
Honorable Mentions can
have their work exhibited at
the Andover Robb Center
in April 2027.

Categories include:

- Youth Perspective
(Ages 7-15)
- Patterns in Nature
- Landscape & Rivers
- Plants & Flowers
- Birds, Bees & Wildlife
- Black & White
- AVIS in Winter



*The lady slipper is both timely and
magical. About 200 lady slippers
can be seen just off the All Persons
Trail at Goldsmith Woodlands in the
spring. Photograph by Susan Stott.*



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